

D617

Public Health Core Functions and Essential Services

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A county health department compiles diabetes rates by ZIP code from hospital and survey data and releases the report at a press conference in the new city hall. Which core function does this activity represent?

- A. Policy development.
- B. Communication, because of the press conference.
- C. Assurance.
- D. Assessment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which activity is an example of the assurance function?

- A. Connecting uninsured residents to a clinic for care.
- B. Tracking flu hospitalizations weekly.
- C. Every activity is assurance.
- D. Drafting a smoke-free parks ordinance.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

Environmental health staff, who recently got new tablets, issue citations and temporarily close restaurants that violate the state food code. Which essential public health service is this?

- A. Assess and monitor population health.
- B. Utilize legal and regulatory actions.
- C. Investigate, diagnose, and address health hazards.
- D. Build and support a diverse workforce.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A mobile mammography van, sponsored by a local bank, visits rural towns to screen women aged 50 to 74 who have no symptoms. Which level of prevention is this?

- A. Tertiary.
- B. It is not prevention because it does not stop cancer.
- C. Secondary.
- D. Primary, since the women have no symptoms.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which of these is primary prevention?

- A. Pap tests for cervical cancer.
- B. HPV vaccination for 11- and 12-year-olds.
- C. Cardiac rehab after a heart attack.
- D. Blood pressure checks at a pharmacy.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A state has funds for one tobacco program. Options include a tax increase and smoke-free workplace laws, or one-on-one quit counseling in clinics. The governor quit smoking years ago. Which will likely have the largest population impact?

- A. Counseling always works best for addiction.
- B. Clinic counseling, because it is personal.
- C. A campaign featuring the governor's quit story.
- D. The tax increase and smoke-free laws.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which intervention type requires the most individual effort and typically reaches the fewest people?

- A. Changing socioeconomic factors.
- B. Making healthy options the default.
- C. Long-lasting protective interventions such as vaccines.
- D. Counseling and education.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A district gives every school \$10,000 for asthma programs. Schools near a major highway have three times the asthma rate. The district recently adopted new school colors. Which change best reflects equity?

- A. Give more funding to the high-burden schools.
- B. Give less to high-burden schools.
- C. Keep the equal \$10,000 split.
- D. Fund new signs in school colors.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

In a town of 100,000, 90,000 adults have low heart attack risk (1% over 10 years) and 10,000 have high risk (5%). The town has two hospitals and a new cardiology wing. Where will most heart attacks occur?

- A. In the high-risk group: 5,000 cases.
- B. In the high-risk group, because its rate is five times higher.
- C. In the low-risk group: 900 vs. 500.
- D. Equal in both groups.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which strategy best reflects the population approach behind the prevention paradox?

- A. Lowering salt in packaged foods for everyone.
- B. Focusing only on high-risk groups always prevents the most cases.
- C. Treating only patients with very high blood pressure.
- D. Screening only people with a family history.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

After a popular podcast episode, residents ask the health department to screen all adults for a rare condition. There is no effective early treatment, and the test produces many false positives. What should the department conclude?

- A.** Screen, since more screening is always better.
- B.** Screen, if the test is cheap.
- C.** Screening is not justified; it fails key criteria.
- D.** Screen, because public demand is high.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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12.

A program offers nutrition classes, works with the school board to change cafeteria menus, and builds new walking paths. It is funded for three years. What best describes the program?

- A.** Health education, because it offers classes.
- B.** Health promotion.
- C.** Medical care.
- D.** Health protection.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A county health department compiles diabetes rates by ZIP code from hospital and survey data and releases the report ~~at a press conference in the new city hall~~. Which core function does this activity represent?

Target word: core function **Decides:** Collecting and analyzing community data.

A	Adjacent category	The data may inform policy, but no policy is made here.
B	Camouflage	The release venue does not change the activity.
C	Confusion set	No service is being delivered or enforced.
D	Correct	Monitoring and analyzing health status is assessment.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

Which activity is an example of the assurance function?

Target word: identify assurance **Decides:** Making sure services reach people.

A	Correct	Assuring access to services.
B	Inverted operation	Assessment.
C	Absolute language	Each function is distinct.
D	Adjacent category	Policy development.

3. Answer B Concept 2

Environmental health staff, ~~who recently got new tablets~~, issue citations and temporarily close restaurants that violate the state food code. Which essential public health service is this?

Target word: essential service **Decides:** Enforcing a legal code.

A	Confusion set	No population data are being tracked.
B	Correct	Enforcement of laws and regulations.
C	Adjacent category	Investigation finds hazards; citations enforce the law.
D	Camouflage	New equipment for staff does not define the service.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A mobile mammography van, ~~sponsored by a local bank~~, visits rural towns to screen women aged 50 to 74 who have no symptoms. Which level of prevention is this?

Target word: prevention level **Decides:** Early detection of existing but hidden disease.

A	Inverted operation	Tertiary limits harm from established disease.
B	Absolute language	Early detection is a level of prevention.
C	Correct	Screening detects disease early.
D	Confusion set	Primary prevents disease from starting.

5. Answer B Concept 3 • transfer

Which of these is primary prevention?

Target word: identify primary **Decides:** Stops disease before it starts.

A	Adjacent category	Screening is secondary.
B	Correct	Prevents infection and later cancer.
C	Inverted operation	Tertiary.
D	Confusion set	Screening, so secondary.

6. Answer D Concept 4

A state has funds for one tobacco program. Options include a tax increase and smoke-free workplace laws, or one-on-one quit counseling in clinics. ~~The governor quit smoking years ago.~~ Which will likely have the largest population impact?

Target word: highest-impact tier **Decides:** Changing context reaches everyone with little individual effort.

A	Absolute language	Population impact favors context change.
B	Inverted operation	Counseling sits at the top: less reach.
C	Camouflage	Education, still a higher tier with less reach.
D	Correct	Context changes make healthy choices the default.

7. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

Which intervention type requires the most individual effort and typically reaches the fewest people?

Target word: top of the pyramid **Decides:** Counseling and education.

A	Inverted operation	The base, with the widest reach.
B	Adjacent category	Second tier, broad reach.
C	Confusion set	Middle tier, one-time effort.
D	Correct	Top tier of the pyramid.

8. Answer A Concept 5

A district gives every school \$10,000 for asthma programs. Schools near a major highway have three times the asthma rate. ~~The district recently adopted new school colors.~~ Which change best reflects equity?

Target word: equity approach **Decides:** Needs differ by school.

A	Correct	Allocates by need to close the gap.
B	Inverted operation	Widens the gap.
C	Adjacent category	That is equality, not equity.
D	Camouflage	Unrelated to need.

9. Answer C Concept 6

In a town of 100,000, 90,000 adults have low heart attack risk (1% over 10 years) and 10,000 have high risk (5%). ~~The town has two hospitals and a new cardiology wing.~~ Where will most heart attacks occur?

Target word: where most cases arise **Decides:** $90,000 \times 1\% = 900$ vs. $10,000 \times 5\% = 500$.

A	Wrong stem number	Applies 5% to the whole town.
B	Inverted operation	Rate is higher but the group is much smaller.
C	Correct	More people at small risk yields more cases.
D	Dropped element	Ignores group size.

10. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

Which strategy best reflects the population approach behind the prevention paradox?

Target word: population strategy **Decides:** Small shift across everyone.

A	Correct	Shifts the whole population's risk slightly.
B	Absolute language	The paradox shows otherwise.
C	Inverted operation	High-risk strategy.
D	Adjacent category	Targeted high-risk approach.

11. Answer C Concept 7

~~After a popular podcast episode,~~ residents ask the health department to screen all adults for a rare condition. There is no effective early treatment, and the test produces many false positives. What should the department conclude?

Target word: screening decision **Decides:** No effective treatment and a poor test.

A	Absolute language	Screening can cause harm without benefit.
B	Dropped element	Cost alone does not meet the criteria.
C	Correct	No effective early treatment and poor accuracy.
D	Camouflage	Demand does not satisfy screening criteria.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A program offers nutrition classes, works with the school board to change cafeteria menus, and builds new walking paths. ~~It is funded for three years.~~ What best describes the program?

Target word: classify the program **Decides:** Education plus policy and environment changes.

A	Dropped element	Ignores the policy and environment parts.
B	Correct	Combines education with policy and environmental supports.
C	Confusion set	No clinical treatment is offered.
D	Adjacent category	Protection focuses on hazards such as food or water safety.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The three core functions	Assessment gathers and analyzes community health data; policy development turns evidence into plans and laws; assurance makes sure needed services, workforce, and enforcement are in place.	Calling any report-writing policy development, or any service assessment.	An activity described by what it produces: data, a policy, or a delivered service.
2	The 10 Essential Public Health Services	The 10 services, with equity at the center, map onto the core functions; for example, enforcing laws and regulations is its own service, distinct from investigating hazards.	Lumping enforcement in with investigation or monitoring.	A specific department activity such as inspecting, citing, monitoring, or training.
3	Levels of prevention	Primary prevention stops disease before it starts; secondary detects it early; tertiary limits harm from established disease.	Calling screening primary prevention because it happens before symptoms.	Whether disease is absent, present but hidden, or established.
4	The health impact pyramid	Interventions that change socioeconomic conditions or make healthy choices the default reach more people with less individual effort than counseling and education.	Assuming education and counseling have the widest reach.	A choice between a policy or environmental change and one-on-one counseling.
5	Equity vs. equality	Equality gives everyone the same resources; equity gives resources according to need to close avoidable gaps.	Treating an equal split as fair when needs differ.	Groups with different burdens receiving the same amount.
6	The prevention paradox	A large number of people at small risk may produce more cases than a small number at high risk, so small shifts across the whole population can prevent more disease.	Assuming most cases come from the high-risk group.	Group sizes and risk rates for high- and low-risk groups.
7	When screening is justified	Screen only when the condition is important, has a detectable early phase, has effective early treatment, and has an acceptable, accurate test.	Believing more screening is always better.	A proposal to screen for a condition with no effective treatment or a poor test.
8	Health education vs. health promotion	Health education builds knowledge and skills; health promotion combines education with policy, environmental, and organizational supports.	Calling a multi-level program health education because it includes classes.	A program that mixes classes with policy or environment changes.

Course scope (public description): Public Health Core Functions and Essential Services builds foundational knowledge by exploring the ethical dimensions, intervention techniques, and educational strategies crucial for effective public health practice. Participants delve into the historical underpinnings, philosophy, and core values of public health, gaining insights into ethical principles guiding decision-making. The course equips students with the skills to design and implement impactful public health programs, emphasizing strategies tailored for health

disparities and equity. The course navigates current issues and trends, providing a forward-looking perspective. Integrating discussions on core functions and the 10 Essential Services, the course fosters a holistic understanding of prevention science across primary, secondary, and tertiary levels in population health, including health promotion and screening. There are no prerequisites for this course.